something, you try and block it out.

‘Boss, this has been going on for months, at least as far back as me breaking my rib and the business about the visit to Buckingham Palace. I’m not enjoying training. I’m not enjoying soccer. I just can’t go on like this.’

When I asked him if he really believed that people sucked up to me, and that I’d changed because of that, I think it caught him off guard. It was a strange moment—a moment of uncertainty—not like anything that had ever gone on between us before. Perhaps he was surprised that Mum and I had talked to each other about his conversation with her or surprised that I didn’t mind him knowing we had. At first he denied saying it and then tried to explain what he’d meant. As far as I could see, the manager was missing the point.

‘I don’t agree with you but put that to one side. Even if you don’t approve of how other people might behave towards me, is it right to blame me for it? To take it out on me the way you have been doing?’

I think the boss agreed with that. The principle of it, anyway. This was too important to me to just leave it there, though.

‘I’m 27 years old now. I think I’ve grown up a bit. And I think, now, I respond better to encouragement than I do to being picked on. The way it’s been the past few months: perhaps, in the past, it might have worked on me. It doesn’t any more. If I’m playing well now, it’s down to me and the support I get at home. It’s in spite of how you’re being towards me, not because of it.’

He assured me that he wasn’t trying to pick on me on purpose. That he wasn’t treating me any differently than he was the other players. I’d said most of what I had to say and it felt strange that the boss hadn’t jumped back at me. It never blew up into anger. Maybe that’s why the meeting didn’t get to where I’d thought it might: either a genuine reconciliation or me telling the boss that I was planning to retire. Instead he said he wanted us to move on:

‘You communicate with me. I’ll communicate with you. We’ll be professional and we’ll go on from there.’

I stood up and went to walkout of the office. The manager said to me in that half-joking, slightly sarcastic way he has:

‘Come here and shake my hand before you start crying.’